



For Insurance, Probably: An Interview Study of Field Purpose on the Independent Motel Check-In Card, and Its Uptake as a Provenance Annotation

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Abstract. The paper card handed across a motel counter at nine in the evening asks for more than the transaction requires: a home address for one night, a vehicle registration nobody checks, a next-of-kin line, an occupation. We report a qualitative interview study of what the people who collect these details believe each field is for. Thirty-eight front-desk staff at twenty-nine independent roadside motels were interviewed with their own centre's card in front of them, alongside a documentary inventory of the cards themselves. The twenty-nine cards carry forty-one distinct fields, of which six appear on all of them; participants offered a purpose for a median of five of the seventeen fields on their own card. Reflexive thematic analysis produced four themes: the field as sediment, purpose inherited by proximity, the unenforced field, and the card as a promise to an absent reader. One accommodation group subsequently adopted our four provenance categories as a required per-field annotation, and its standard card grew from seventeen fields to twenty-three. Completion time at the desk rose, blank fields fell, and the share of fields staff could account for did not move. We observe that the instrument travels more readily than the understanding it was built to describe.

Introduction

It is nine in the evening on a highway that has run out of towns, and the card on the counter wants your home address. It also wants the registration of the car outside, the number of people in the room, a signature, a next-of-kin contact and, on eleven of the twenty-nine cards we collected, your occupation. The room is ninety-five dollars and you will be gone by seven. Nobody at the desk will look at the card again, and the person handing it over cannot, if asked, say what most of it is for.

The literature on administrative burden treats this asymmetry as a cost borne by the person filling in the form [1], and the red-tape tradition treats it as rule without commensurate function [2]. Data-protection practice supplies the corresponding principle from the other direction: collection should be limited to what the stated purpose requires [3], a limit that presumes the

purpose can be stated. What has attracted less attention is the counter itself — the staff member who prints, presents, collects and files the card, and who is the only party to the transaction present at every stage.

This paper takes that person as the informant and the card as the object. We asked front-desk staff at independent roadside motels, card in hand, what each field was for; we inventoried the cards; and we then followed the study's own categories into the compliance review of one accommodation group. Our contributions are three, each stated with the caution the evidence supports:

- an interview account of field-level purpose knowledge at the point of collection, which suggests that the ability to justify a field and the practice of collecting it come apart routinely rather than exceptionally;

- a four-theme description of how purpose is reconstructed at the desk when it is not known, which may transfer to other counter-issued forms;
- a brief observational note on what a compliance review does with those themes once it holds them, offered tentatively and consistent with the reactivity literature.

Background

Records are not passive containers. The clinical record has been shown to constitute the work it documents rather than merely describe it [4], and coordinative artefacts in design and planning settings carry the ordering of practice inside their own layout [5]. Paper's particular affordances — its portability, its tolerance of annotation, its availability to several people at a counter at once — have been catalogued as design resources rather than deficits [6]. Classification research supplies the standing caution: schemes are never neutral, and what a category makes countable it also makes finished [7].

A second line concerns the work that formal systems do not see. Much of what holds an operation together is invisible in its own records [8], and making that work visible is itself a design intervention with consequences [9]. Where the formal system misfits, staff adapt around it in goal-directed ways better read as accommodation than as noncompliance [10], and the routine that results is a source of change rather than a frozen rule [11]. Sensemaking accounts describe the retrospective character of the explanations people give for what they are already doing [12] — a mechanism our second theme reproduces almost exactly.

Privacy scholarship gives the collection itself a vocabulary: over-collection is a distinct harm from disclosure, and identification and aggregation are separate activities with separate consequences [13]. The checklist literature supplies the cautionary parallel from practice, where an instrument's adoption has repeatedly outrun the conditions that made it work [14].

Prior work at this institution has approached the same seam from the records side. A study of community garden allotment handovers found a form's substantive content to be a genuine predictor of what a successor retained, which a mandatory-completion intervention could not reproduce by raising completion alone [15].

A pool network that retired its paper sign-in ledger saw no movement in incident-report completion or dispute-resolution time, but a sharp fall in staff confidence that an incident could be reconstructed from the centre's records [16]. A dyadic study of vehicle service intake found that 36% of a customer's spoken account of a fault reached no field on the job card in any form [17]. Each treats a record whose felt purpose and demonstrated function have parted company; none asks the person holding the pen what the fields are for.

Method

Setting and sampling

We sampled independently owned and operated roadside motels — no franchise, no central reservation system — along three regional highway corridors. Twenty-nine properties agreed to participate. All twenty-nine used a paper check-in card completed at the counter, in eleven cases alongside a separate electronic booking record. Recruitment continued until information power was judged sufficient for the study's narrow aim and specific sample [18], a point reached at twenty-nine properties and consistent with the range empirical work reports for thematic saturation [19].

Participants and interviews

Thirty-eight staff took part: owner-operators ($n = 14$), employed receptionists ($n = 19$) and relief or family staff covering the desk irregularly ($n = 5$). Tenure at the property ranged from three weeks to thirty-one years (median six years). Interviews were semi-structured, conducted on site and off-shift where possible, and ran 41 to 74 minutes (median 52). Each was audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim. Reporting follows the consolidated criteria for qualitative research [20].

The interview was built around the participant's own card. Each field was indicated in turn and the participant was asked what it was for, who used it, and what happened when a guest left it blank. Probes were non-directive; the interviewer did not supply candidate purposes.

Documentary corpus

We photographed and transcribed all twenty-nine cards, coding every printed field to a common inventory. The corpus contains 41 distinct fields. Six appear on all twenty-nine cards; nine-

teen appear on fewer than five. The median card carries 17 fields.

For each participant j we record an explanation coverage over the field set F_j printed on their own card, writing $p_{j,f}$ for the purpose offered for field f :

$$e_j = \frac{1}{|F_j|} \sum_{f \in F_j} \mathbb{1}[p_{j,f} \neq \emptyset]$$

The median was $e = 0.29$ — five fields of seventeen. Figure 1 gives the per-field picture across the twelve most widely printed fields.

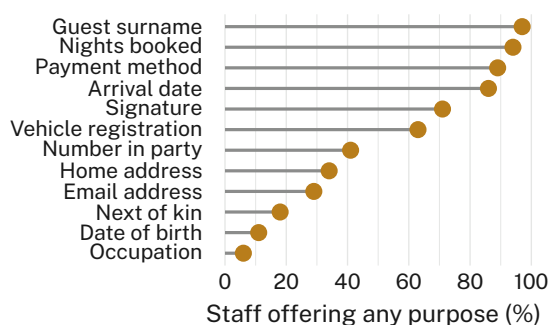


Figure 1: Share of the 38 participants offering any purpose for a field, shown against their own centre's card. No participant offered a purpose for the occupation field beyond that it was printed there.

Analysis

Transcripts were analysed by reflexive thematic analysis [21], applied with the reflexive rather than the coding-reliability orientation the method's authors distinguish [22]. Two researchers coded independently to a codebook that stabilised at nineteen codes over four passes; a third adjudicated disagreements in discussion rather than by coefficient. Four themes were constructed. To test the codebook's contribution, we re-ran the analysis against a collapsed eleven-code variant (Figure 3).

Findings

The field as sediment

Every participant who could account for a field accounted for it by a single remembered event. A vehicle registration line was traced to a fuel-drive-off in 2011; a next-of-kin field to a guest taken to hospital “years back, before my time”; an occupation field to a request from an unspecified authority that no participant could date. Nineteen of the thirty-eight described at least

one field as having been added after an incident. None could name a field that had ever been removed.

The documentary record supports them. Figure 2 gives the field count on the standard card of the one participating group with a retained revision history; across seventeen years and seven revisions, the count only rises.

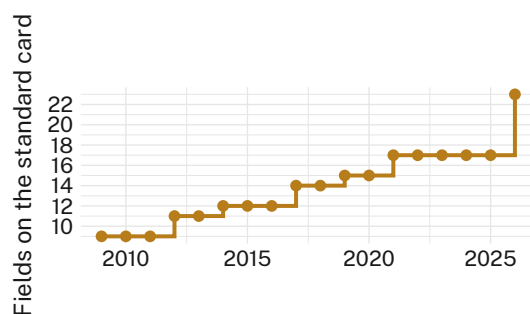


Figure 2: Fields on one accommodation group's standard card, 2009–2026. No revision in the series removed a field.

Purpose by proximity

Where a purpose was not known, it was reconstructed from the card's layout. A date-of-birth field was repeatedly explained as “part of the licence bit” because it sat beneath the licence number; an email field printed beside the payment block was described as being for receipts at properties that email no receipts. Participants moved fluently between “I think it's for” and “it's for” within a single answer, and the account offered was consistently the one the neighbouring field would have supported — retrospective sensemaking of the kind the organising literature describes [12]. Four participants revised their answer mid-interview on noticing what the field was actually next to.

The unenforced field

A field whose purpose could not be stated was not a field staff pursued. Asked what happened when a guest left occupation blank, twenty-six of the thirty-eight said, in substance, nothing. The same participants described chasing surname, registration and signature without hesitation. Blank fields in the corpus concentrate where explanation fails: the eight fields with the lowest explanation coverage account for the large majority of blanks we observed. The card is therefore not one instrument but two — a short one that is enforced and a long one that is printed.

A promise to somebody absent

The card was consistently described as being completed for a reader who was not present and had never been met: an inspector, an insurer, “the police, if it ever came to that”, a family member to be telephoned. No participant reported having seen any of these readers consult a card. Three had been asked for a card once. This absent reader organised the whole transaction — the pen placed on the counter, the card squared to the guest, the file drawer behind the desk — without ever arriving.

The ablation

Collapsing the nineteen-code codebook to eleven codes changes the number of themes carried per interview by 0.04 (Figure 3), which is well inside the spread of the observations themselves; all four themes survive the reduction intact. We retain the full codebook for completeness.

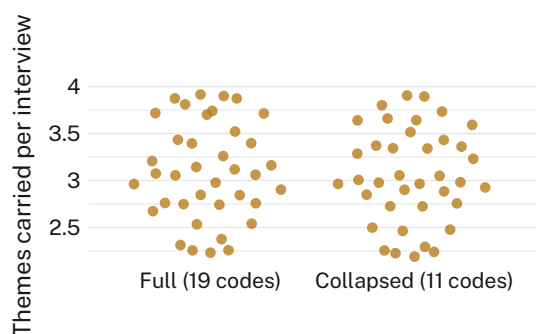


Figure 3: Themes carried per interview under each codebook, one point per interview. The two distributions are not distinguishable (n.s.).

After the review

One group operating eleven of the twenty-nine properties received our themes and brought them to its scheduled compliance review. The review adopted the four provenance categories as a required per-field annotation: each field on the standard card now carries, in a narrow right-hand column, the authority under which it is held. The card grew from seventeen fields to twenty-three, the six additions being the annotation column’s own header fields and two new declarations the review considered adjacent.

In the twelve weeks following, median completion time at the desk rose from 96 seconds to 2 minutes 41 seconds, and the share of fields left blank fell from 22% to 9%. Re-interviewed staff at the eleven properties (n = 14) offered a purpose for 33% of the fields on the new card,

against 31% before the review — a difference we do not read as movement.

Discussion

The instrument behaves as instruments of its kind are expected to: it describes its domain, it survives reduction, and it is adopted. Its adoption is the more interesting result. Once provenance is a category, provenance becomes a thing a card can record, and the group’s compliance posture improves without any observed change in what the people at the counter understand about the fields they collect — the pattern the reactivity literature anticipates, in which a public measure reshapes the conduct it was built to describe [23], and which accounts of transparency regimes have long identified as the cost of making a practice legible [24]. Classification research would treat the outcome as ordinary rather than perverse: the categories rendered something countable and, in doing so, rendered it finished [7].

We would not characterise the result as an artefact. Fewer fields are blank, the provenance of each field is now written down where before it was not, and the guest at nine in the evening is still handing over an address for one night.

Limitations

Our frame is independent roadside motels in three corridors, though the consistency of the four themes across properties of very different size and tenure suggests the account is not local to them. Our follow-up covers one group of eleven properties over twelve weeks, which is short; we report it as an observation rather than an evaluation. Explanation coverage is a coarse measure that credits any offered purpose, including several we judged to be incorrect, and so if anything overstates what is understood at the desk.

Conclusion

The fields on a motel check-in card outlive the reasons for them, and the people who collect them reconstruct those reasons from the layout when asked. Where the reconstruction is formalised, the card grows. Future work will follow the annotation column through a second revision cycle, and ask whether a field whose provenance is recorded is any more likely than

one whose provenance is not to be the first thing removed.

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